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Artisans

1.5 Artisans

Potter

1.5.1 Potter

Potter’s wheel

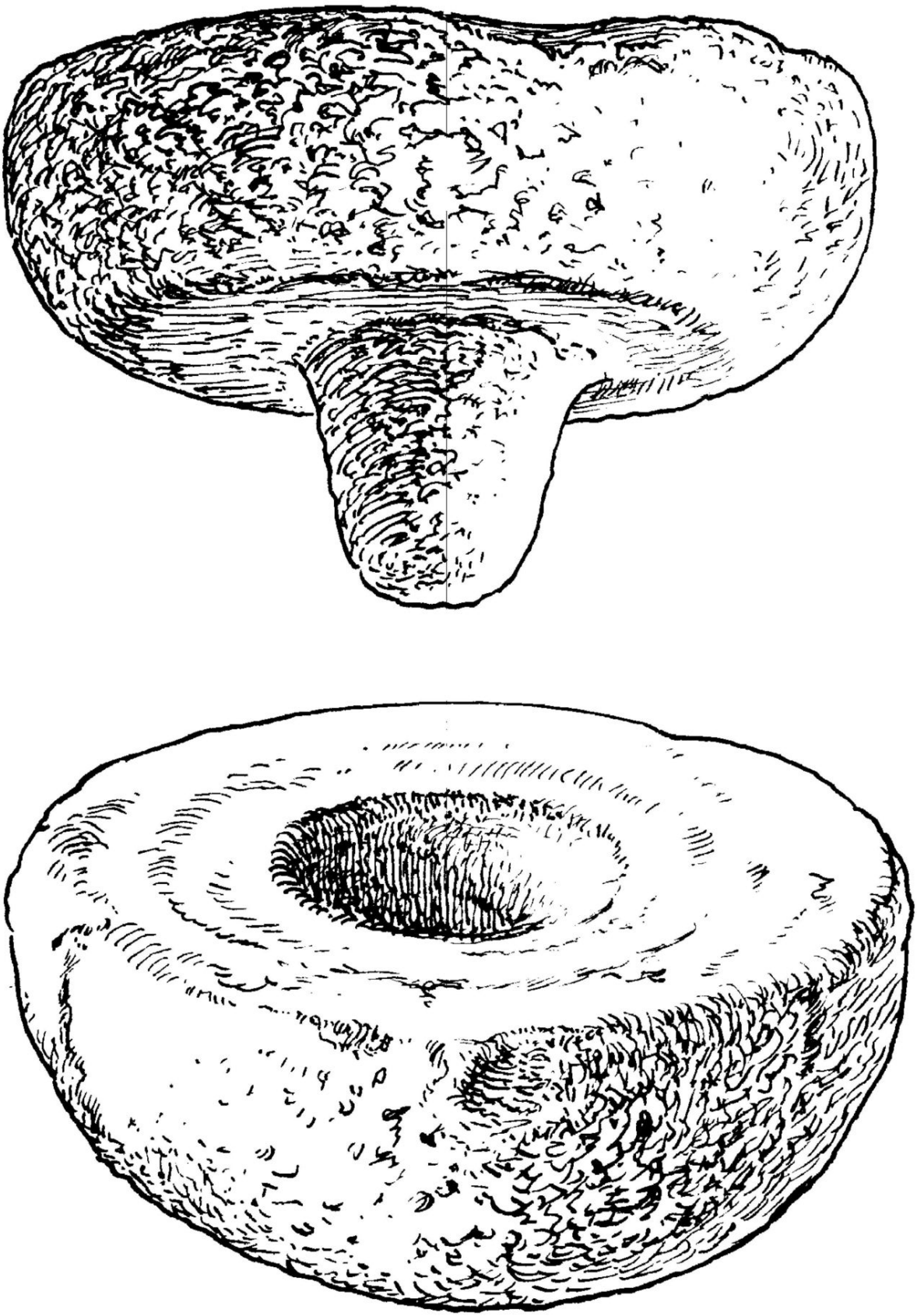
1.5.1.1 Potter’s wheel

References:

Hebrew אָבְנַיִם (’ovnayim) JER 18:3

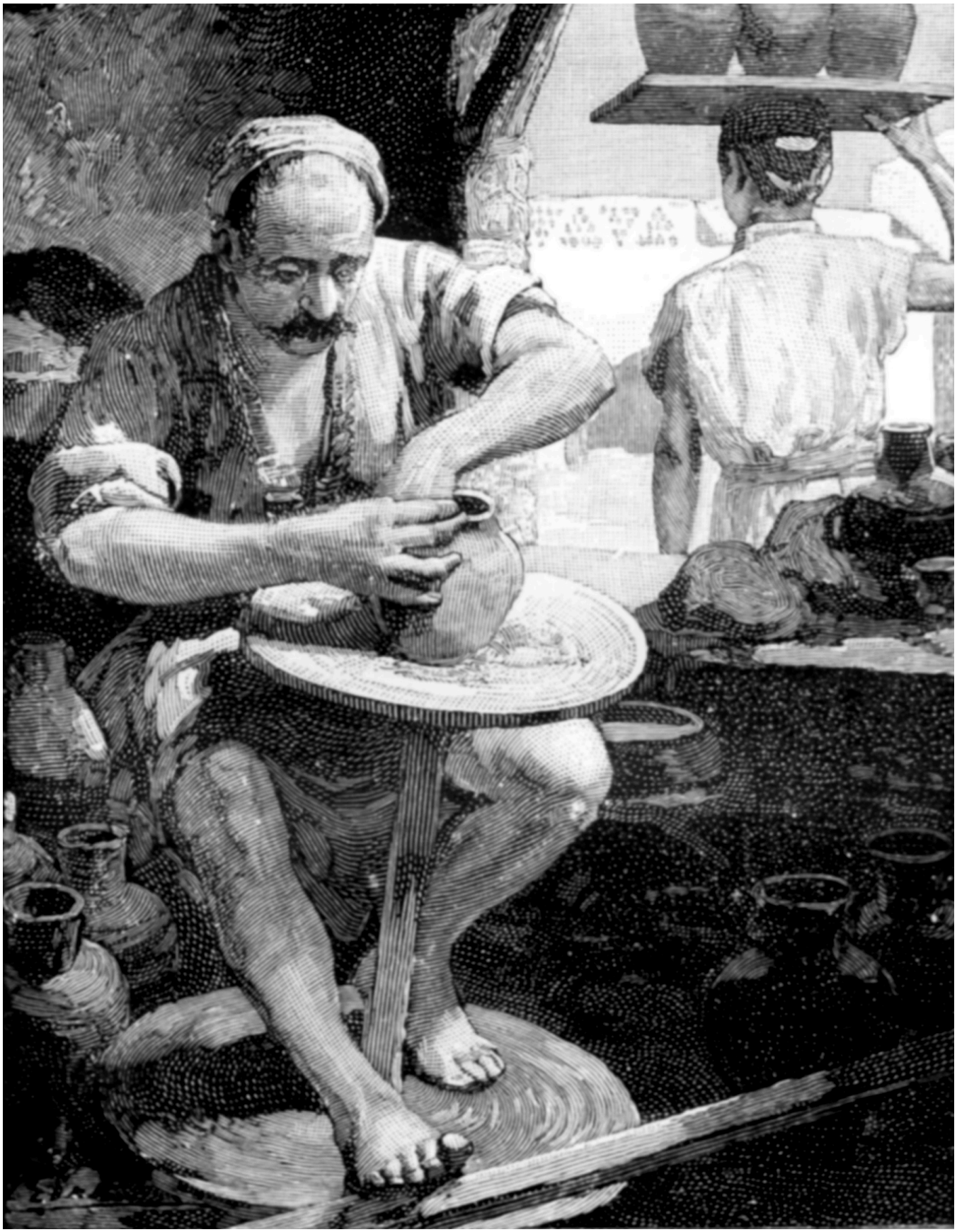
Greek τροχός (trochos) SIR 38:29

Description:



Potter’s wheel (Old Testament times) (© Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft, Stuttgart by United Bible Societies)In Old Testament times the potter’s wheel was a flat, horizontal wheel made of stone. On the underside of the stone there was a pointed projection. This projection sat in an indentation on a stationary lower stone and served as an axis around which the upper stone turned. The stone was turned by hand or perhaps by a person other than the potter. In intertestamental and New Testament times the construction was different. An upper wheel, made of wood, was connected by a shaft to a second, larger wheel situated below. The upper wheel was at a height convenient for the potter to work when seated.

Usage:



Potter turning wheel with his foot (New Testament times) (The Pictorial New Testament, The Religious Tract Society 1881, Public domain)Clay was placed in the center of the upper wheel. The wheel was turned by hand or by foot. In the latter period, the spinning of the lower, heavier wheel caused the upper one to spin also. The potter used his fingers to form the spinning clay into the desired shape. See SIR 38:29: “It is the same with the potter, sitting at his wheel and turning it with his feet ...” (GNT).

Translation:

The context of JER 18:1; JER 18:2; JER 18:3; JER 18:4 makes it clear that the potter is using the “wheel” to help him make clay pots. However, if it is felt that “wheel” would be misleading, translators may say “work table.”

Glue

1.5.1.2 Glue

Reference:

Greek συγκολλάω (sugkollaō (verb)) SIR 22:9

Description and usage:

Glue is an adhesive substance used to stick one thing to another.

Translation:

While nearly all languages have a word for adhesive substances, the Greek text of SIR 22:7 actually uses a verb, and many translations will prefer to describe the action of sticking two things back together; for example, GNT has “Trying to teach a fool is like gluing a broken pot back together ....” Some languages may distinguish between different kinds of adhesives. The glue chosen here should be appropriate for sticking together pieces of earthenware pottery.

Engraver, woodcarver

1.5.2 Engraver, woodcarver

Engraving, carving

1.5.2.1 Engraving, carving

References:

Hebrew חרשׁ, חָרָשׁ (charash) EXO 28:11, EXO 35:35, EXO 38:23, JER 17:1

Hebrew חֲרֹשֶׁת (charosheth) EXO 31:5, EXO 31:5, EXO 35:33, EXO 35:33

Hebrew פתח (pathach (verb)) EXO 28:9, EXO 28:11, EXO 28:36, EXO 39:6, 1KI 7:36, 2CH 2:6, 2CH 2:13, 2CH 3:7, ZEC 3:9

Hebrew פְּתוּחַ (pituach) EXO 28:11, EXO 28:21, EXO 28:36, EXO 39:6, EXO 39:14, EXO 39:30, 2CH 2:6, 2CH 2:13, PSA 74:6, ZEC 3:9

Hebrew קלע, מִקְלַעַת (qala‘ (verb), miqla‘ath) 1KI 6:18, 1KI 6:29, 1KI 6:29, 1KI 6:32, 1KI 6:32, 1KI 6:35, 1KI 7:31

Greek γλύμμα (glumma) SIR 38:27, SIR 45:11

Greek γλυφή (glufē) WIS 18:24

Greek γλύφω (glufō (verb)) WIS 13:13, SIR 38:27

Greek ἐγγλύφω (egglufō (verb)) 1MA 13:29

Greek κολάπτω (kolaptō (verb)) SIR 45:11, 3MA 2:27

Description:

Engraving on a ring (© The Portable Antiquities Scheme/ The Trustees of the British Museum, CC BY-SA 2.0, via Wikimedia Commons)An engraving was a picture or words made by scratching lines in a hard surface such as stone, metal, or gems. A carving was a figure usually made out of wood, using a knife or another sharp implement.

Translation:

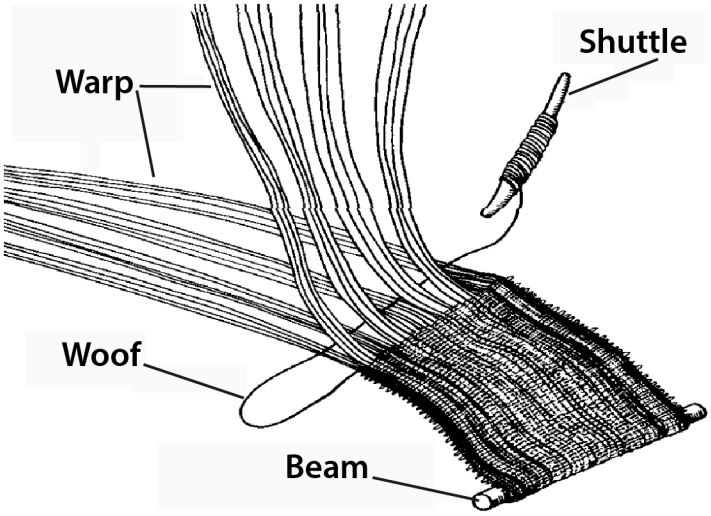
In some languages it may be necessary to choose a verb for “engrave” according to the surface that is being used.

The Hebrew word charosheth is used in EXO 31:5 and EXO 35:33 to describe both engraving and carving.

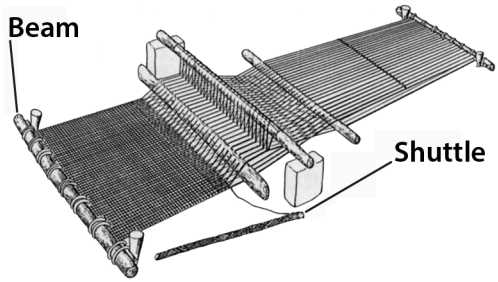
The specific action described in SIR 38:27 is “engrave seals” (NJB; compare the even more precise RSV rendering “cut the signets of seals”; see also the discussion at 10.2 Seal, signet ring, ring<REALIA:10.2>). The point of the passage is the diligence and precision with which the engraver works. Where there is no exact equivalent of signets or seals, it is possible to refer to some other craftsman’s work that requires precision and can be done in great variety.

Cloth manufacture

1.5.3 Cloth manufacture



Weaving (Source unknown)



Loom (Source unknown)Weaving was the art of making cloth. First the thread was prepared from the unspun fibers. This was done by attaching a piece of the fiber to a short, pointed piece of wood (the **spindle**) and then spinning it while drawing out the fiber into thin, spun thread. The thread thus spun was wound onto the spindle. After the threads were prepared, it was necessary to interlace them at right angles. The **loom** was a device designed to weave cloth in this manner. In the horizontal loom, a series of threads were wound around a thick wooden beam and then tied to another beam. These threads, called the warp, were slightly separated and kept under tension. From the side of the warp another thread (called the woof or weft) was inserted, over the first warp thread, then under the next, and so on until it was passed through the entire warp. To aid this process, the woof thread was attached to a small flat piece of wood or bone, called the **shuttle**. The shuttle, with the woof thread attached, was passed successively back and forth through the warp to form the interwoven cloth.

Thread, string, yarn

1.5.3.1 Thread, string, yarn

References:

Hebrew חוּט (chut) GEN 14:23, JOS 2:18, JDG 16:12, ECC 4:12, SNG 4:3

Hebrew פָּתִיל (pathil) GEN 38:18, GEN 38:25, EXO 28:28, EXO 28:37, EXO 39:3, EXO 39:21, EXO 39:31, NUM 15:38, NUM 19:15, JDG 16:9, EZK 40:3

Description:

A piece of string (Image generated by ChatGPT using OpenAI technology)Thread or yarn for weaving was made by twisting fibers on a spindle (see 1.5.3 Cloth manufacture<REALIA:1.5.3>). A single strand of thread made in this way was not particularly strong, but cloth made by interweaving many of these thin strands together was strong enough for many uses. See also 1.14 Rope, cord<REALIA:1.14>.

Translation:

The essential difference between “thread” or “string” and “cord” or “rope” was less in its thickness than in its composition. A rope or cord was made of two or more single strands twisted or braided together. All the occurrences of the Hebrew word pathil are listed here, but in one or two of the passages the translator may consider that a heavier cord is intended.

In EXO 39:3 the Hebrew word pathil is used to refer to fine “threads” (RSV, CEV) or “strands” (NIV) made of gold. Some languages may have a separate word for such a “filament” made of metal.

Spindle

1.5.3.2 Spindle

References:

Spindle:

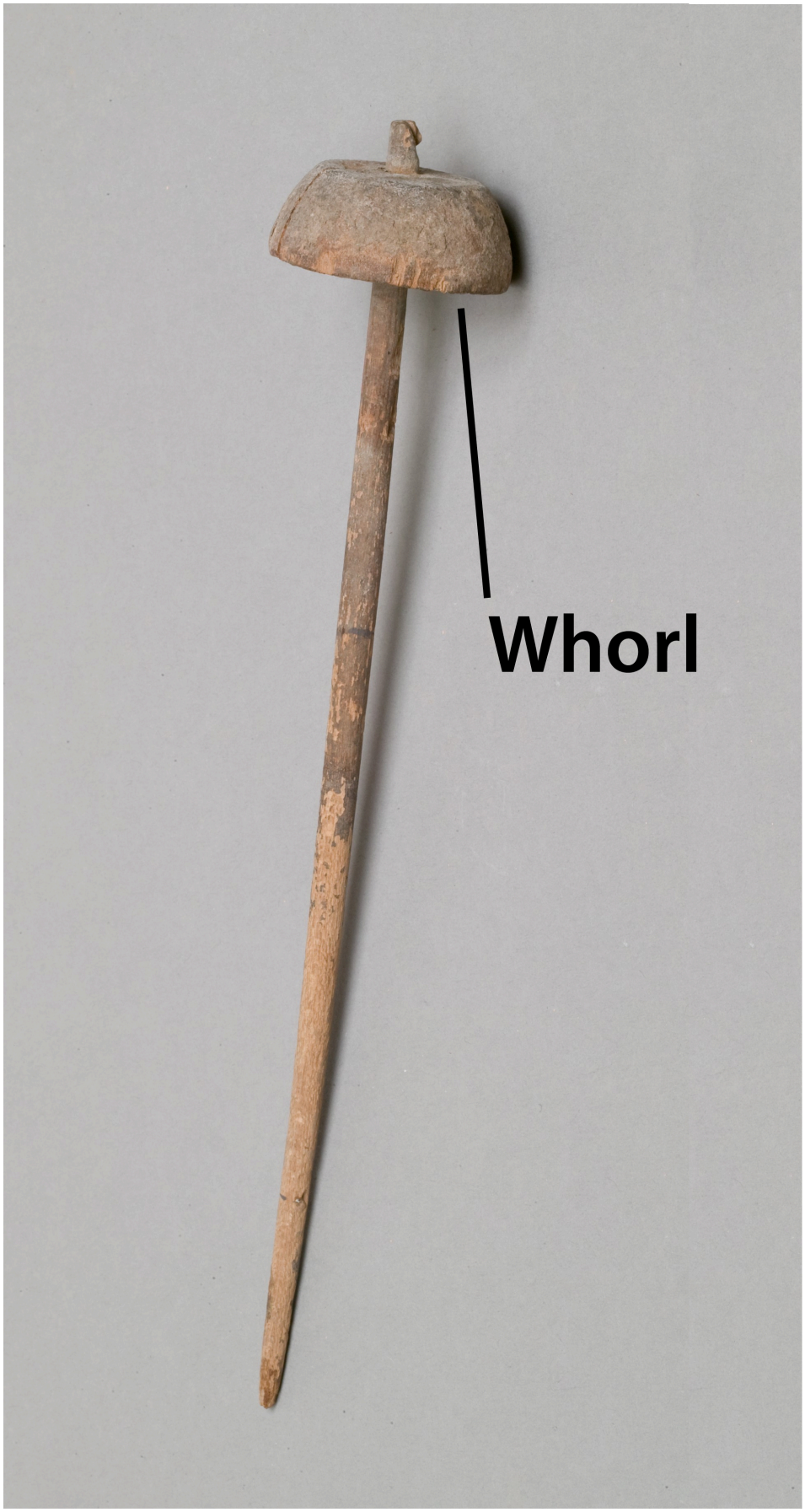
Hebrew כִּישׁוֹר (kishor) PRO 31:19

Hebrew פֶּלֶךְ (pelek) 2SA 3:29, PRO 31:19

Whorl:

Description and usage:

Description and usage:



Spindle (Metropolitan Museum of Art, CC0, MMA)After the fibers had been drawn out, one end of the fibers was attached to the spindle, which was a short, oblong stick with a weight on the top (the whorl). The spindle was suspended in the air and spun, thus spinning the attached fibers into a thread. As the thread grew longer, it was then wrapped around the middle of the spindle until all of the fiber had been drawn out and spun.

The action of the spindle resulted in a strong “spun thread.” The Hebrew word for this spun or twisted thread is shazar (always appearing in the form moshzar) in PRO 31:19, EXO 26:31, EXO 26:36; EXO 27:9, EXO 27:16, EXO 27:18; EXO 28:6, EXO 28:8, EXO 28:15; EXO 36:8, EXO 36:35, EXO 36:37; EXO 38:9, EXO 38:16, EXO 38:18; EXO 39:2, EXO 39:5, EXO 39:8, EXO 39:24, EXO 39:28; EXO 39:29, and the Greek word is klōthō in SIR 45:10.

Translation:

Woman using a spindle (© Rita Willaert, CC BY 2.0, via Wikimedia Commons) PRO 31:19: The literal RSV translation of this verse reads “She puts her hands to the distaff, and her hands hold the spindle,” but this will communicate little to modern readers in most cultures. Common-language translations generally describe the activity of the woman rather than the specific instruments she is using. GNT has “She spins her own thread and weaves her own cloth.” NCV goes one step further, describing the act of spinning: “She makes thread with her hands and weaves her own cloth.” CEV has attempted to simplify this verse even further but has probably gone too far with “She spins her own cloth”; a person does not “spin” cloth, even if the intended audience understands the operation of spinning.

Weaver’s beam

1.5.3.3 Weaver’s beam

References:

Hebrew אֶרֶג, מָנוֹר (mnor ’orgim) 1SA 17:7, 2SA 21:19, 1CH 11:23, 1CH 20:5

Greek ἱστός (histos) ODA 11:12

Description:

Vertical loom (© CristianChirita, CC BY-SA 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons)The weaver's beam was a wooden rod approximately 5–6 centimeters (2–2.5 inches) in diameter. The length could vary. Around this beam the warp threads were attached, and the cloth was rolled on it as it grew in length.

Usage:

See 1.5.3 Cloth manufacture<REALIA:1.5.3>.

Translation:

In the Old Testament references, it is the exceptional size of each giant's spear that is in focus. In 1SA 17:7CEV has taken into account that weaving on a hand loom is little known today in western English-speaking countries, so it has omitted reference to the weaver's beam by saying "and his spear was so big ...." Where hand weaving is not commonly known, translators may want to follow this pattern. Another possible model is "and the shaft of his spear was twice as thick as an ordinary spear ...."

The Greek word histos in ODA 11:12 may refer to either the beam or the entire loom. It is usually not necessary to render this word literally; compare NRSV "a piece she had woven" or NJB "a piece of work."

Shuttle

1.5.3.4 Shuttle

References:

Hebrew אֶרֶג (’ereg) JDG 16:14, JOB 7:6

Description and usage:

The shuttle was the small device used by the weaver to carry the "woof" (or "weft") thread from one side of the loom to the other. The shuttle darted quickly across the loom, between the "warp" threads, leaving the woof thread stretched behind. The warp threads then closed over and under the woof thread, holding it in place. In this way another line of thread was added to form the cloth. A skilled weaver caused this to happen quite rapidly, with the shuttle moving back and forth constantly, until a whole piece of cloth was formed. See 1.5.3 Cloth manufacture<REALIA:1.5.3> and the illustrations there.

Translation:

When Samson was startled from sleep in JDG 16:13; JDG 16:14, he tore apart the various elements of the makeshift loom Delilah had prepared for weaving his hair. These included the "pin," the "shuttle," and the "fabric," into which she had woven Samson's hair. Some translations (RSV, NIV) inaccurately render the Hebrew word ’ereg as "loom" here.

In JOB 7:6 one day is compared to one swift movement of the shuttle.

Beater, batten, pin

1.5.3.5 Beater, batten, pin

Reference:

Hebrew יָתֵד (yathed) JDG 16:14, JDG 16:14

Description and translation:

The Hebrew word yathed, which appears twice in JDG 16:14, has been understood in various ways. It is possible that Delilah tried to anchor Samson's hair to the ground with a kind of tent peg, which is the normal meaning of the word (see 3.2.2 Tent peg, stake<REALIA:3.2.2>). However, it seems more likely that yathed here refers to part of the weaving equipment used by Delilah. One possibility is that it was a peg in the wall from which were hung the vertical threads. This possibility is given in the CEV rendering, which reads "While Samson was asleep, Delilah wove his braids into the threads on a loom and nailed the loom to a wall. Then she shouted, 'Samson, the Philistines are attacking!' Samson woke up and pulled the loom free from its posts in the ground and from the nails in the wall. Then he pulled his hair free from the woven cloth." It is perhaps most likely that yathed here refers to a kind of bar that was used to push the woof threads down tight (along with Samson's hair). This is reflected in the rendering of RSV, which has "So while he slept, Delilah took the seven locks of his head and wove them into the web. And she made them tight with the pin, and said to him, 'The Philistines are upon you, Samson!' But he awoke from his sleep, and pulled away the pin, the loom, and the web."

Woven or knitted material

1.5.3.6 Woven or knitted material

References:

Hebrew דַּלָּה (dalah) ISA 38:12

Hebrew עֵרֶב (‘erev) EXO 12:38, LEV 13:48, LEV 13:49, LEV 13:51, LEV 13:52, LEV 13:53, LEV 13:56, LEV 13:57, LEV 13:58, LEV 13:59, NEH 13:3, JER 25:20, JER 50:37, EZK 30:5

Hebrew שְׁתִי (shthi) LEV 13:48, LEV 13:49, LEV 13:51, LEV 13:52, LEV 13:53, LEV 13:56, LEV 13:57, LEV 13:58, LEV 13:59, ECC 10:17

Description and usage:

Woven cloth (Source unknown)See 1.5.3 Cloth manufacture<REALIA:1.5.3>.

Translation:

The following is adapted from A Handbook on Leviticus at LEV 13:48 (page 200): Older translations such as the King James Version (KJV) and RSV translated the Hebrew words shthi and ‘erev as “warp” and “woof,” and this is the meaning that the words of the text have taken in modern Hebrew. Such a rendering indicates the threads

going in different directions in the cloth. However, it is highly unlikely that this is the meaning of the text. It is difficult to see how the threads going in one direction could be affected by the mildew without affecting those running at right angles to them. The requirement that the affected part be torn out does not make sense either (verse 56), because this would destroy the whole garment. While the interpretation is far from certain, the meaning of these words is probably “woven or knitted material,” as in NAB, TOB and NIV (similarly American Translation [AT]). GNT has reduced this to “piece [of clothing],” but such a reduction should probably be avoided in the receptor language, if possible.

In ISA 38:12 Hezekiah is complaining that his life is to be cut short. He uses a weaving metaphor to say that his life is like cloth cut off from the warp, the vertical threads of the loom.

Linen

1.5.3.7 Linen

References:

Hebrew אֵטוּן (’etun) PRO 7:16

Hebrew בַּד (bad) EXO 28:42, EXO 39:28, LEV 6:3, LEV 6:3, LEV 16:4, LEV 16:4, LEV 16:4, LEV 16:4, LEV 16:23, LEV 16:32, 1SA 2:18, 1SA 22:18, 2SA 6:14, 1CH 15:27, EZK 9:3, EZK 9:3, EZK 9:11, EZK 10:2, EZK 10:6, EZK 10:7, DAN 10:5, DAN 12:6, DAN 12:7

Hebrew בּוּץ (buts) 1CH 4:21, 1CH 15:27, 2CH 2:13, 2CH 3:14, 2CH 5:12, EST 1:6, EST 8:15, EZK 27:16

Hebrew סָדִין (sadin (see) JDG 14:12, JDG 14:13, PRO 31:24, ISA 3:23

Hebrew פִּשְׁתָּה (pishteh) LEV 13:47, LEV 13:48, LEV 13:52, LEV 13:59, DEU 22:11, JER 13:1, EZK 40:3, EZK 44:17, EZK 44:18, EZK 44:18

Hebrew שֵׁשׁ (shesh) GEN 41:42, EXO 25:4, EXO 26:1, EXO 26:31, EXO 26:36, EXO 27:9, EXO 27:16, EXO 27:18, EXO 28:6, EXO 28:8, EXO 28:15, EXO 28:39, EXO 28:39, EXO 35:6, EXO 35:23, EXO 35:25, EXO 35:35, EXO 36:8, EXO 36:35, EXO 36:37, EXO 38:9, EXO 38:16, EXO 38:18, EXO 38:23, EXO 39:3, EXO 39:5, EXO 39:8, EXO 39:27, EXO 39:28, EXO 39:28, EXO 39:28, EXO 39:29, PRO 31:22, EZK 16:10, EZK 16:13, EZK 27:7

Greek βύσσινος (bussinos) REV 18:12, REV 18:16, REV 19:8, REV 19:8, REV 19:14, 1ES 3:6

Greek βύσσος (bussos) LUK 16:19

Greek λίνον, λινοῦς (linon, linous) REV 15:6, JDT 16:8

Greek ὀθόνιον (othonion) LUK 24:12, JHN 19:40, JHN 20:5, JHN 20:6, JHN 20:7

Greek σινδών (sindōn) MAT 27:59, MRK 14:51, MRK 14:52, MRK 15:46, MRK 15:46, LUK 23:53

Description:

Lazarus lying in the tomb wrapped in linen cloth (Image generated by ChatGPT using OpenAI technology)Linen is a high quality cloth made from the stems of the flax plant. It was known for its strength and coolness.

Usage:

Most flax in Israel was imported from Egypt and used for a wide range of products. The Bible mentions bed coverings, sails of ships, garments for the priests, furnishings for the tabernacle, burial clothes, and other things. See also Plants and Trees in the Bible, 5.1.7 Flax (linen)<FLORA:5.1.7>.

Translation:

In a number of languages there is no term for “linen,” and though a word for “linen” may be borrowed, what is important in many contexts is primarily the quality of the cloth, not the material from which it was made. Accordingly, many translators have used an expression such as “fine [white] cloth” or “good cloth.” In some cases it will be possible to say “cloth made from the fibers of a plant.” It may be necessary to add an explanatory footnote.

In several passages the important characteristic of linen is that it causes less perspiration than other cloths (see EXO 39:27; EXO 39:28; EXO 39:29; LEV 6:10; LEV 16:4; EZK 44:17; EZK 44:18). Where linen is not known, translators should choose a cloth with a similar characteristic.

In MAT 27:59; MRK 15:46; and LUK 23:53, the Greek word sindōn describes the cloth with which Jesus’ body was wrapped for burial. This is also true for the Greek word othonion in LUK 24:12; JHN 19:40; JHN 20:5; JHN 20:6; JHN 20:7. Where a language has a special word for such a “burial cloth” or “shroud,” it should be used.

Wool

1.5.3.8 Wool

References:

Hebrew צֶמֶר (tsemer) LEV 13:48, LEV 13:52, LEV 13:59, DEU 22:11, ISA 51:8, EZK 44:17

Greek ἔριον (erion) HEB 9:19

Description:

Wool is the soft wavy hair of sheep and certain other animals. It was used to weave a fabric from which clothing was made.

Translation:

In some languages translators may have to render “wool” as “cloth made from the hair of a sheep.”

Silk

1.5.3.9 Silk

References:

Hebrew מֶשִׁי (meshi) EZK 16:10, EZK 16:13

Greek σιρικόν (sirikon) REV 18:12

Description:

Silk was a fine, expensive cloth made from the fiber produced by the silkworm in making its cocoon.

Translation:

Translations and commentaries vary on the translation of the Hebrew word meshi in EZK 16:10; EZK 16:13. The traditional translation has been “silk,” which is still followed by many versions (KJV, RSV, GNT, NCV). Others consider this to be unlikely in the time of Ezekiel, when silk was not yet known in the Middle East. It has been suggested that the word indicates a kind of veil worn by the woman, hiding her face from others but allowing her to see out. Translations that reject “silk” as the proper translation usually find a more general term. Compare CEV “most expensive robes,” NRSV “rich fabric,” GECL “a beautiful, woven robe,” TOB “expensive cloth,” and REB “fine linen.”

In the first-century A.D. setting of REV 18:12, it is quite possible to speak of proper silk. However, it cannot be determined from the context of this verse whether the Greek word sirikos refers simply to cloth or to garments made of silk.

Purple cloth

1.5.3.10 Purple cloth

References:

Hebrew אַרְגָּוָן (’argewan) 2CH 2:6, DAN 5:7, DAN 5:16, DAN 5:29

Hebrew אַרְגָּמָן (’argaman) EXO 25:4, EXO 26:1, EXO 26:31, EXO 26:36, EXO 27:16, EXO 28:6, EXO 28:8, EXO 28:15, EXO 28:33, EXO 35:6, EXO 35:23, EXO 35:25, EXO 35:35, EXO 36:8, EXO 36:35, EXO 36:37, EXO 38:18, EXO 38:23, EXO 39:3, EXO 39:8, EXO 39:24, EXO 39:29, NUM 4:13, JDG 8:26, 2CH 2:13, 2CH 3:14, EST 1:6, EST 8:15, PRO 31:22, SNG 3:10, SNG 7:6, JER 10:9, EZK 27:7, EZK 27:16

Hebrew חָמוּץ (chamuts) ISA 63:1

Hebrew כַּרְמִיל (karmil) 2CH 2:6, 2CH 2:13, 2CH 3:14

Hebrew שָׁנִי (shani) GEN 38:28, GEN 38:30, JOS 2:18, JOS 2:21, 2SA 1:24, PRO 31:21, SNG 4:3, ISA 1:18, JER 4:30

Hebrew תלע (tala‘) NAM 2:4

Hebrew תּוֹלָע (tola‘) ISA 1:18, LAM 4:5

Hebrew תּוֹלַעַת שָׁנִי, (tola‘ath shani, shni tola‘ath) EXO 25:4, EXO 26:1, EXO 26:31, EXO 26:36, EXO 27:16, EXO 28:6, EXO 28:6, EXO 28:8, EXO 28:15, EXO 28:33, EXO 35:6, EXO 35:23, EXO 35:25, EXO 35:35, EXO 36:8, EXO 36:35, EXO 36:37, EXO 38:18, EXO 38:23, EXO 39:3, EXO 39:3, EXO 39:5, EXO 39:8, EXO 39:24, EXO 39:29, LEV 14:4, LEV 14:6, LEV 14:49, LEV 14:51, LEV 14:52, NUM 4:8, NUM 19:6

Hebrew תְּכֵלֶת (tekeleth) EXO 25:4, EXO 26:1, EXO 26:4, EXO 26:31, EXO 26:36, EXO 27:16, EXO 28:6, EXO 28:8, EXO 28:15, EXO 28:28, EXO 28:31, EXO 28:33, EXO 28:37, EXO 38:18, EXO 38:23, EXO 39:3, EXO 39:5, EXO 39:8, EXO 39:22, EXO 39:24, EXO 39:29, EXO 39:31, NUM 4:7, NUM 4:9, NUM 4:11, NUM 4:12, NUM 15:38, 2CH 2:6, 2CH 2:13, 2CH 3:14, EST 1:6, EST 8:15, JER 10:9, EZK 23:6, EZK 27:7, EZK 27:24

Greek κόκκινος (kokkinos) MAT 27:28, HEB 9:19, REV 17:4, REV 18:12, REV 18:16

Greek κόκκος (kokkos) SIR 45:10

Greek πορφύρα (porfura) MRK 15:17, MRK 15:20, LUK 16:19, REV 18:12, JDT 10:21, SIR 45:10, LJE 1:71, 1MA 4:23, 1MA 8:14, 1MA 10:20, 1MA 10:62, 1MA 10:64, 1MA 11:58, 1MA 14:43, 1MA 14:44, 2MA 4:38, 1ES 3:6

Greek πορφυροῦς (porfurous) JHN 19:2, JHN 19:5, REV 17:4, REV 18:16, LJE 1:11

Greek πορφυρόπωλις (porfuropōlis) ACT 16:14

Greek ὑακίνθινος (huakinthinos) SIR 6:30, SIR 40:4

Greek ὑάκινθος (huakinthos) SIR 45:10, 1MA 4:23

Description:

Purple cloth was a reddish-purple cloth dyed with substances obtained from several natural sources. The primary source was the murex shellfish. Another source (referred to in the Hebrew words with the root tla‘) was a small worm. The dying process could yield a variety of colors, ranging from a dark red through purple to blue. (see 1.5.3.14 Dye<REALIA:1.5.3.14>.)

Usage:

The relatively limited source for the purple color and the complicated process for its production made purple cloth extremely expensive and thus available only to kings and the richest families. In time the color came to be associated with royalty, although only several centuries after biblical times did legislation actually forbid its use by people outside the royal family.

Translation:

In a number of languages there is no special color term for reddish-purple, since the color in question is sometimes classified as a kind of blue and in other instances it is related to black. Sometimes it may be described as “dark red” or even “bluish red.” However, in all languages it is possible to be somewhat more precise about color terms by likening the color to that of a local flower, bird, or something else.

In many verses in Exodus (for example, EXO 25:4), three colors in this range are mentioned together. Many translations have “blue,” “purple,” and “scarlet/red.” Where possible the translator should find three colors within this range. A Handbook on Exodus (page 582) has the following helpful comments on EXO 25:4: “It may be difficult to distinguish between the three colors, or they are all various shades of a mixture of red and blue. The difference between the words for **blue** and **purple** seems to be that the first has more blue and the second has more red. But both colors were purple. NJB translates these tow terms as ‘violet-purple’ and ‘red-purple.’ ” For guidelines on translating the color purple, see A Handbook on The Gospel of Mark, page 482.

In many of the references to purple cloth, the important element is not the color but the high rank implied by cloth of that color. Translators may prefer to make this information explicit. For example, at 1MA 10:64 for the literal clause “saw him clothed in purple” (RSV), GNT has “saw him clothed in royal robes.”

If it is necessary to designate what kind of cloth was dyed purple, translators should, where possible, choose a cloth that indicates high rank or dignity.

Embroidered cloth, needlework

1.5.3.11 Embroidered cloth, needlework

References:

Hebrew מַעֲשֶׂה, רקם (ma‘aseh roqem) EXO 26:36, EXO 27:16, EXO 28:39, EXO 36:37, EXO 38:18, EXO 39:29

Hebrew רִקְמָה (riqmah) JDG 5:30, JDG 5:30, PSA 45:15, EZK 16:10, EZK 16:13, EZK 16:18, EZK 26:16, EZK 27:7, EZK 27:16, EZK 27:24

Greek ποικιλτής (poikiltēs) SIR 45:10

Description:

Linen cloth embroidered with wool (© EgyArt, via Wikimedia Commons)Embroidered cloth was cloth into which decorative patterns or figures were sewn by hand. Because of the extra work that went into it, embroidered cloth was expensive.

Translation:

Where there is no word for “embroidery,” it is possible to use a descriptive expression; for example, in EXO 26:36NCV has “Someone who can sew well is to sew designs on it,” and in EZK 27:7 it says “linen with designs sewed on it.” Where even this is difficult to express in the receptor language, translators may say simply “fancy linen” or “decorated cloth.”

Patch

1.5.3.12 Patch

References:

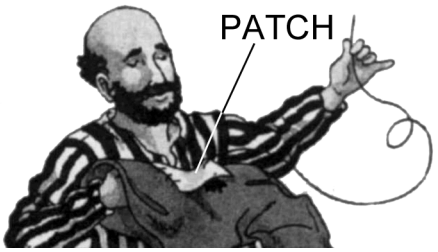
Hebrew טלא (tala’ (verb)) JOS 9:5

Greek ἐπίβλημα (epiblēma) MAT 9:16, MRK 2:21, LUK 5:36, LUK 5:36

Greek πλήρωμα (plērōma) MAT 9:16, MRK 2:21

Greek ῥάκος (rhakos) MAT 9:16, MRK 2:21

Description and usage:



Patches sewn on an old waterskin (Gary Todd, Israel Museum, CC0, via Wikimedia Commons)The patch was a piece of cloth or leather sewed on clothing or shoes to repair a hole or tear.

Translation:

JOS 9:5: The shoes of the Gibeonite messengers had been “patched” many times, that is, repaired with pieces of leather.

MAT 9:16 and MRK 2:21: The statement that “No one patches up an old coat with a piece of new cloth” (GNT) seems almost preposterous or incredible in some societies, since people habitually repair old clothing by putting on patches of new cloth, sometimes to the point where it is difficult to determine what was the original fabric. However, the Greek phrase rhakous agnafou, often translated “new cloth,” is literally “unshrunken cloth,” that is, cloth that has not been washed several times to shrink it (DUCL “patch that has never been shrunken”; similarly RSV, REB, NJB).

Linen cloth, sheet

1.5.3.13 Linen cloth, sheet

References:

Greek ὀθόνη (othonē) ACT 10:11, ACT 11:5

Description:

The sheet was a large piece of cloth, usually of linen (see 1.5.3.7 Linen<REALIA:1.5.3.7>).

Translation:

The Greek word othonē is a general term for a piece of linen cloth that was used for a variety of objects, including a cloth that a person could wrap around himself as clothing or a sail for a boat. In its context in Acts, it has four corners and is large enough to hold a large number of animals. In translation it will not normally be necessary to indicate that the “cloth” or “sheet” was made of linen.

Dye

1.5.3.14 Dye

References:

Hebrew אדם (m’adam) EXO 25:5, EXO 26:14, EXO 35:7, EXO 35:23, EXO 36:19, EXO 39:34

Hebrew צְבַע (tseva‘) JDG 5:30, JDG 5:30, JDG 5:30

Description and usage:

Dye was a substance used to color materials, especially textiles. Dyes came from minerals, plants, insects (for example, all those based on the Hebrew root tla‘ were from a small worm), and sea animals (in particular, certain mollusks).

Translation:

Translators and commentators differ concerning the exact meaning of the Hebrew word m’adam. Most understand it to mean that the rams’ skins or sheepskins (which it always modifies) have been “dyed red” (GNT, NIV, NJB) or “colored red” (FRCL, PV). However, RSV, CEV, and REB say “tanned” (see 1.13 Leather<REALIA:1.13>).